

While shopping looks different today, people still treat it as a leisure activity. Instead of thinking critically about boredom and healthy ways to spend our time, we can just pull out our phones and one-click-buy or get in the car and drive to Target. Picnicking in the park is free, but it isn't getting a lot of advertising, so it's not top of mind when we're thinking of things to do. Recently I saw an ad for a dollar sale at the local resale store and planned a group shopping trip with friends. I didn't need anything, it just seemed like a cool way to hang out with friends. I'm guilty of doing this at Sam's Club too. I know when they bring out the free samples, so sometimes I'll go just for the samples even though I know I'll inevitably walk out with something that was not free.

A growing number of scientists are actually devoting research to why we shop to overcome boredom. Processed healthily, boredom is your brain signaling for change. It indicates that a current activity or situation isn't providing engagement or meaning in hopes of provoking you to shift your attention to something more fulfilling. Processed unhealthily, boredom leads to impulsive decision-making.

Because of boredom's negative connotation, people who get bored easily are often undervalued in society. As children they're seen as immature, troublemakers, having short attention spans, and as adults their decisions can be seen as impulsive and irresponsible. First, if that sounds like you and you've ever been made to feel this way, we want you to know you are no less capable of success than people who don't "get bored" easily. Second, you have an edge that others don't. It may seem like a hindrance because a lot of traditional success involves conformity, but boredom can be your strength once you start pursuing healthy ways of responding to it.

So, what can you do if having fun for you requires spending money?

First, figure out the things you like that don't cost money! Half the battle is trying new things so you know what you do and do not like. We often spend money on a small group of activities that we know we like because we don't want to try something new that we may not like. But part of building your creative muscles is to do new stuff. Where deprivation requires giving up your needs, values-based spending requires getting creative in how you meet them. Not everything will be fun, and you don't have to force something to be fun for you because someone else likes it. I (Jen) personally hate thrifting. I love shopping secondhand online, but I hate hunting through thrift stores. Jill loves it! She lives for it! But as much